



WEEK EIGHT · MODULE TWO

The First Year, Honestly

The last confidential note, and the one I most wish someone had given me

THE PRIVATE CONCIERGE ACADEMY

Maison Amarine · Confidential · For the use of our mentees only

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HOW TO STUDY THIS MODULE

This note is not about technique. There is no technique left to teach you.

It is about what the first year actually feels like from the inside, and what it costs, and why the people who leave almost never leave for the reason they give.

Read it now, and then read it again in your sixth week, which is exactly when you will need it and exactly when you will not remember that it exists.

CHAPTER I

The crash at week six

It comes for everybody, and it is not a sign

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Recognise the crash before it happens.

Understand that it is a phase and not a verdict.

The first two weeks are exhilarating. You are careful, you are alert, you are learning at an extraordinary rate, and every day contains something you have never seen before.

And then, somewhere around week five or six, it arrives, and it arrives for everybody.

What you feel

What is actually happening

I am not good at this. You are now aware of how much you do not know. In week one you were not. This is not a decline. It is the first honest measurement you have taken.

They have realised I am not what they hoped. They have realised nothing. They are not thinking about you at all, which is precisely what you were hired to achieve.

Everybody else understands this house and I do not. They have been here for nine years. You have been here for thirty-eight days.

I am exhausted and I do not know why. You are performing constant, invisible, high-stakes attention in a house where you cannot yet relax. It is genuinely tiring in a way that no previous job has been, and it does ease.

THE THING TO HOLD ON TO

The crash at week six is not information about your ability. It is a phase, it is universal, and it passes at around week ten.

Almost nobody is told this, and so a very large number of capable people conclude, in their sixth week, that they have made a terrible mistake. Some of them resign. They were, without exception, four weeks from the other side of it.

CHAPTER II

The loneliness

The real cost of this profession, and nobody says it

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Understand what the work actually costs.

Build the thing that protects you, before you need it.

I am going to say the thing that the brochures do not.

This work is lonely. Not sometimes. Structurally.

- You cannot tell your partner about your day. Not the interesting parts, not the difficult parts, not the funny parts. Not ever, and not in ten years.
- You cannot tell your friends where you were, or who was there, or what happened, and after a while they stop asking, and something in the friendship quietly thins.
- You are inside a family's life, at the closest possible range, and you are not in it, and both of those facts are true every single day.
- You are with the staff, and you are not one of them. You are with the family, and you are certainly not one of them. There is a chair in that house that is yours alone, and nobody else is ever going to sit in it.

2.1 · What protects you

The protection	Why it matters
A life outside the house	Real, protected, and defended. Friendships that have nothing to do with this world. A flat that is yours. A Sunday that belongs to you. The professionals who last are the ones who built this in month one, not in year three when they needed it.
One or two peers in the profession	People who understand, with whom you can speak in generalities and never in specifics. Not a support group. A colleague, and a very small number of them, and it is the single most valuable thing you can build.
The days off, taken	Actually taken. The martyr who never takes them is not being loyal, she is building a resentment that will arrive, all at once, in month nine, and it will end the role.

The protection**Why it matters**

A record that is not a
confidant

Your log, your manual, your systems. The place where the weight of what you
carry goes, so that it does not go into a conversation.

And the thing that does not protect you, and that will present itself as the answer:
becoming close to the principal. It will feel like being chosen. It will fill exactly the space
the loneliness has made. Read Week 3 again. It is the confidante trap, and this is the door
through which it comes.

CHAPTER III

When to speak, and when to hold

The judgement that takes ten years, compressed into a page

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Know what must be said, what may be said, and what is never said.

Category	Examples, and the rule
Must be said, immediately	Anything unsafe. Anything illegal. Anything involving the children. Any error of yours that has a cost. Any risk they cannot see. Speed is not optional here, and no consideration of your own position outweighs it.
Must be said, once, privately	A decision you believe is a mistake. You say so once, briefly, with the reason and an alternative, in private. And then, if they still want it, you do it, well, and without sulking, and you never mention it again.
May be said, when asked	Your opinion on a matter within your remit. Give it plainly and briefly. Not asked, not given, is a reasonable rule for your first year.
Never said	Your view of their marriage, their children, their spending, their friends, their choices. Your comparison to another house. Your feelings about being tired. Anything about one principal, to the other.

THE LINE, WHICH TOOK ME YEARS TO FIND

You are paid for your judgement about the work, and never for your judgement about their life.

Every catastrophic overstep in this profession, every single one, is a person who confused the two, and who did it slowly, and who was certain they were being helpful.

CHAPTER IV

How to be kept

The five things, and none of them are effort

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Understand what actually produces longevity.

The quality	Why it decides everything
Consistency	The same person on Tuesday as on Sunday, in year one and in year four, on the good days and on the day after the terrible one. This is the rarest quality in a household and it is the one that is actually being bought.
Discretion, held forever	Not while employed. Forever. And they will not know you have held it, which is the whole point, and it is the only virtue in this profession that is invisible even to its beneficiary.
Bad news at full speed	The single most valuable habit you can have. It is worth more than any amount of excellence, because it means they never have to wonder what they have not been told.
No appetite	You do not want their life. You are not impressed. You are not collecting stories. You have no second agenda, and, over four years, this becomes visible, and it is the thing that makes you safe.
The absence of drama	You do not create weather. You have no feuds, no wounds, no campaigns. A household is a small space, and a person who generates emotional weather in it is a cost, however talented they are.

Notice what is not on that list. Brilliance is not on it. Speed is not on it. Impressive contacts are not on it. Working eighty hours a week is not on it, and in fact it is a warning sign, and every experienced principal knows it.

You are kept because you are safe, consistent, and quiet. That is the entire answer, and it is the answer at the end of eight weeks, and it will still be the answer in twenty years.

CHAPTER V

How to leave

Because one day you will, and it matters enormously

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Leave a house in a way that pays you for a decade.

You will leave. Everybody does. The family relocates, the children grow up, the role changes, the right offer comes, or it simply ends.

How you leave is worth more to your career than most of what you did while you were there, because it is the last thing anybody remembers, and it is what they will describe when they are asked.

- **Give proper notice, and more than you owe if you can.** The person who gives eight weeks when the contract said four is remembered for a decade.
- **Hand over completely.** The manual, the suppliers, the systems, the file. Everything. You leave the house better than a house that never had you, and you leave nothing in your own head.
- **Train your successor, generously, and speak well of the house to them.** Even if it was hard. Especially if it was hard.
- **Take nothing.** Not the preference file. Not the supplier list that belonged to the house. Not a photograph, not a small thing that nobody would miss, not a story to tell.
- **Say nothing, forever.** The NDA is the floor. Your silence continues after it expires, after they die, after everyone has forgotten. That is not a legal position. It is who you have decided to be.
- **And never, ever, speak badly of them afterwards.** Not to your next employer, not to an agency, not at a dinner in ten years when everybody else at the table is telling stories. Especially then.

CHAPTER VI

Case law

*Six first years***LEARNING OBJECTIVES**

Recognise these before you live them.

The reformer

She was, by a distance, the most capable person they had hired. She saw, in her first fortnight, that the household ran on habit rather than system, and she was entirely right.

So she fixed it. Suppliers renegotiated, processes rewritten, the housekeeper's Thursday routine reorganised, all of it defensible, all of it better.

By week three the staff had closed around her like water. By month five she was gone.

Everything she changed was an improvement. Every single one of them was correct. And she had made eleven people's lives harder in a fortnight in order to be right, and a house will always choose peace over efficiency, and she never understood that, and I believe she still does not.

The names

A young woman, no household experience, a chalet season behind her and very little else. On her first day she wrote down the name of every person in the house. The gardener. The night driver. The woman who came on Thursdays to do the flowers.

She learned them that evening and she used them the next morning.

By the end of her first month the staff had adopted her, and when the estate manager left eighteen months later, three separate people told the principal, without being asked, that she should have the role. She got it, at twenty-nine, and every one of those recommendations traces back to a piece of paper on her first afternoon.

The sixth week

A man in his forties, a serious career behind him, four weeks into a very good household role, telephoned a friend in this profession and said that he had made a mistake, that he was not capable, that he was going to resign before he was asked to.

The friend said one sentence: "Everybody feels that at week six. Call me at week ten."

He is still in that house, eleven years later. **Nothing about his ability changed between week six and week ten. He simply survived a phase that nobody had told him existed.** This case is the entire reason Chapter I of this note is written.

The forty minutes

A house manager, four months in, made an error that cost the family a little under a thousand euros. Trivial, in that house. Genuinely trivial.

She spent forty minutes deciding whether to mention it.

She did mention it, in the end, that evening, and it was absorbed without a word, and nothing was ever said about it again.

And she told me, years later, that those forty minutes were the most frightening of her professional life, and that she has never allowed herself to have them again. **Every person who was destroyed by a concealment began with forty minutes exactly like hers. She is the only one who came out of them the right way, and she is still in that house.**

The one who took her days off

Two women joined the same household in the same month. One never took a day off. She was always available, always there, always the one who said yes on a Sunday, and she made sure, gently, that it was known.

The other took every day off she was owed, and was entirely present when she was working, and unavailable when she was not, and never once made a performance of either.

The first was exhausted by month four and resentful by month six, and she left in month nine believing she had been undervalued, and in a sense she was right.

The second is still there. The house trusts her more, not less, because a person with a life is a person who is not going to break.

The one who left well

Six years in a house, and then it ended, for reasons that were not her fault and were not theirs.

She gave twelve weeks. She wrote the manual she had never quite finished. She trained her successor for a month, generously, and spoke well of the family to her, including about the difficult year.

She took nothing. She has never told anybody who they were.

That was fourteen years ago, and she has not applied for a role since. Every position she has held in fourteen years came to her, from someone in that house, or someone who heard about her from someone in that house. That is what leaving well is worth, and it is worth more than any single year she spent there.

Glossary

The crash at week six · The universal collapse of confidence in the fifth or sixth week. It is a phase, not a verdict, and it passes at about week ten.

The chair · The position you occupy in a household. Not staff, not family, and nobody else will ever sit in it.

The forty minutes · The time spent deciding whether to disclose a mistake. Every destroyed career began in them.

Weather · Emotional turbulence generated by a member of staff. A household will remove it, however talented its source.

Leaving well · Full notice, complete handover, nothing taken, nothing said, forever. Worth more than most of the years you served.

Self-assessment

The last of the programme. Take your time with the final question.

1. What is the crash at week six, when does it pass, and what will you do when it arrives?
2. Name the four structural loneliness of this work. Then name the four things that protect you from them.
3. Why is becoming close to the principal the most dangerous answer to loneliness, and how will you recognise it in yourself?
4. Write the line between judgement about the work and judgement about their life, and give one example of each.
5. Name the five qualities that get a person kept. Then say honestly which one you do not yet have.
6. You disagree with a decision. Describe exactly what you do, including what you do afterwards.
7. You will leave a house one day. Write, now, the six things you will do when it happens.
8. In the case of the reformer: she was right about everything. Explain, without sentimentality, why that did not save her.
9. In the case of the forty minutes: what is actually being described, and why is it the most important case in this note?
10. It is the night before your first day. What do you read, and why?

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